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**HARPER
BUSINESS**

**What Do The World's Top Performers Have In Common?
Dr. Henry Cloud Spent 30 Years Finding Out**

*New book, Your Desired Future: The Five Essential Steps That Take You Where You Want to Go,
releases May 5, 2026*



NASHVILLE, TN — You have goals you haven't reached. A version of your business, your relationships, or yourself that exists only in your mind. You're not alone, and according to Dr. Henry Cloud, you might not be the problem.

In “Your Desired Future: The Five Essential Steps That Take You Where You Want to Go” (Harper Business; on sale May 5, 2026), the *New York Times* bestselling author and clinical psychologist delivers the book he has spent three decades earning the right to write: a step-by-step action plan to rid yourself of the limiting patterns and thinking that are holding you back from reaching your highest potential.

"The problem is rarely talent, intelligence, or opportunity," said Dr. Cloud. "The problem is that most people don't follow the path that virtually all successful outcomes share. Once you see it, you can't unsee it."

The premise is deceptively simple: how do you move from your current state (here) to a desired future state (there)? Drawing on psychology, physiology, and neuroscience, and inspired by how the human body itself functions, Dr. Cloud introduces five components essential to every successful outcome, whether you are leading a business, rebuilding a relationship, developing a space program, or making permanent changes to your lifestyle:

1. **Vision:** Establishing a clear, compelling, and desired future state that serves as a guiding force.
2. **Talent & Resources:** Identifying and engaging the right people and tools necessary to achieve the vision.
3. **Strategy & Plan:** Developing a structured approach to achieving goals, including specific steps and strategies.
4. **Measurement & Accountability:** Tracking progress against objectives and holding oneself and others to account.
5. **Adaptation & Problem-Solving:** Quickly recognizing issues and implementing solutions to stay aligned with goals.

The framework isn't motivational, it's structural. Grounded in decades of performance research and neuroscience, it explains not only what these components are, but why they so often fail, and exactly how to execute them in the way that achieves the desired result.

With more than 20 million copies sold across 45 books, including the multi-million-copy bestseller *Boundaries*, Dr. Cloud brings his signature warmth and disarming clarity to what many call the most frustrating question in human life: why don't we become the people, leaders, and organizations we know we're capable of being?

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Dr. Henry Cloud is a clinical psychologist, leadership expert, and New York Times bestselling author whose books have sold over twenty million copies worldwide. Named by *Success* magazine as one of the top 25 leaders in the field, his work spans executive coaching, organizational transformation, and personal growth. He holds a BS in psychology from Southern Methodist University and a PhD in clinical psychology from Biola University. He lives in Nashville, Tennessee.

BOOK DETAILS

Your Desired Future: The Five Essential Steps That Take You Where You Want to Go

Author: Dr. Henry Cloud

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www.drcloud.com

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Suggested Interview Questions:

1. What inspired you to write *Your Desired Future*, and what do you hope readers take away from it?
2. Can you explain the five-step model for achieving goals and how it applies to both individuals and organizations?
3. You use your dog Finley as a metaphor throughout the book. Can you explain what "barking at the door" means and why so many talented people stay stuck in that pattern?
4. How can people overcome internal limits, like fear of failure or negative self-talk, to pursue their vision?
5. You write that "the human body knows best" when it comes to achieving goals. What do you mean by that, and how can we apply what the body naturally does to our personal and professional lives?
6. What's the difference between having a vision and having a fantasy? How do you turn a dream into something that actually happens?
7. Can you share a story or example from the book that illustrates how these principles have been successfully applied?
8. If readers could implement just one principle from your book today, what would it be and why?
9. You mention that most people don't fail because they lack talent or intelligence. So why do so many smart, capable people fail to reach their desired futures?
10. What's the biggest mistake people make when trying to achieve a goal, and how can they avoid it?

Business & Leadership

1. What advice do you have for leaders trying to engage the right talent and create a high-performing team?
2. You emphasize the importance of psychological safety and a positive emotional climate. How can leaders foster these in their teams?
3. How can individuals and organizations develop a winning strategy while addressing their weaknesses and leveraging their strengths?
4. What is the difference between lagging and leading indicators, and why is focusing on leading indicators so critical?
5. Accountability is often seen as punitive, but you frame it differently. How can leaders use accountability as a positive force for achieving goals?
6. You tell a story about working with a CEO named Jared whose business unit had stalled. What was the problem, and how did applying the five essentials turn things around?
7. Many leaders tend to build companies "in their own image," with the same strengths and weaknesses they have. How can leaders recognize this tendency and ensure all five essentials are present?
8. You discuss the importance of "fix and adapt" as the fifth essential step. How can leaders create a culture where problems are solved quickly before they become entrenched patterns?
9. What's the difference between a problem and a pattern, and why does that distinction matter for organizational performance?
10. You worked with executives for over three decades. What separates leaders who consistently achieve their vision from those who don't?
11. How should leaders structure accountability conversations so they feel supportive rather than threatening to team members?
12. You mention that sometimes the fix for poor performance is "fix me first" as a leader. Can you elaborate on what you mean and give an example?

Couples & Relationships

1. How can couples apply the five essential steps to improve their relationship or work toward shared goals together?
2. You talk about the importance of "engaging talent". What does that look like in a marriage when both partners need to contribute different strengths?
3. Many couples have a shared vision for their future but never seem to get there. What's usually missing, and how can they get back on track?
4. Accountability can be especially difficult in intimate relationships. How can couples hold each other accountable without it feeling like criticism or control?
5. You write about psychological safety in teams. How does that apply to creating a safe emotional climate in marriage?
6. What happens when one partner is ready to work toward a goal but the other isn't fully on board? How do you create "mutually agreed-upon expectations" in a relationship?
7. How can couples identify and address patterns (not just problems) that keep them stuck in the same conflicts or disappointments?

Parenting

1. How can parents use the five essential steps to help their children develop healthy goal-setting habits?
2. You tell a story about your daughter Lucy wanting to become a singer-songwriter. How did you help her create a plan to achieve that vision, and what happened?
3. What does "engaging talent" look like when parenting? How do parents know when to let kids struggle and when to bring in outside help?
4. Many parents struggle with holding their kids accountable without being too controlling or too permissive. What's the right balance, and how do you frame accountability positively?
5. You share the "Daddy Court" story about your daughters bringing disputes to you. Can you explain that and what it teaches about teaching kids to solve their own problems?
6. How can parents help kids develop a vision for their future without imposing the parents' own dreams on them?
7. What's the difference between helping kids succeed and doing things for them that they should be doing themselves? How do you avoid the "co-dependent" trap in parenting?